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CPS says schools will open on time

King offers few details on reversing layoffs of teachers, support staff

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago Public Schools leaders told families Thursday that classes will begin on schedule, but they gave few details about how the district might reverse layoffs after the board approved a budget that counts on \$150 million in new state funding.

CPS CEO Macquiline King said last week she was unsure whether schools would start as planned. She warned the school board’s revised \$10.11 billion budget could make lenders less willing to provide short-term loans needed to cover payroll.

But during a community webinar Thursday, King said officials “feel really comfortable and confident that school will open on time, with no interruptions.”

The \$150 million budget amendment, passed by board members aligned with the Chicago Teachers Union, calls on the district to reverse the layoffs of 760 teachers and 800 school-based support staff announced last month. That money also would cover a proposed midyear spending freeze, though it depends on the district securing the unconfirmed state aid.

Principals, however, will not need to reopen their school budgets, a CPS spokesperson said. It’s still unclear how or whether the district will add back laid-off positions.

CTU sent a letter to district leaders Monday, obtained by the Tribune, asking for impact bargaining to “ensure the prompt rescission of layoff notices” issued to its members.

The union and its allies argue the revised budget is a pressure tactic to force Springfield to confront decades of underfunding of CPS. They also point to recent commitments from several lawmakers to lobby for more money, including Illinois House Speaker Emanuel “Chris” Welch.” The union also notes the district is only considered 73% fully funded under the state’s own funding formula.

The union criticized the district for saying the school calendar might be affected by the revised budget, telling members last week that CPS “sent an email to parents to warn that the sky is falling” and “representing bankers’ interests over the interests of our school communities.”

But district leaders countered that the budget is not balanced under state law, and argued it could lead to midyear cuts if the money doesn’t come through. Because lenders and credit rating agencies are skeptical of unconfirmed revenue, the move could lead to credit downgrades and higher borrowing costs, officials said.

Getting additional funding from

See **SCHOOLS** on Page A2

Mag Mile shopping center to get revamp

The owner of The Shops at North Bridge will pour \$40 million into a dramatic renovation of the complex, giving the Magnificent Mile another jolt of energy. **Business**

Blanche gets key support from senator

Republican Sen. Bill Cassidy said that he will back Todd Blanche’s nomination as attorney general, likely paving the way for Blanche’s confirmation to lead Trump’s Justice Department. **Nation & World**



Workers remove bodies from the South Chicago Chapel in the South Deering neighborhood on Friday. The remains of over 50 people were discovered the day before at the funeral home in the 2900 block of East 95th Street. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘I WANT TO SEE SOME JUSTICE’

Families, officials call for change amid probe into funeral home where dozens of decomposing bodies were found

By Allison Kiehl, Caroline Kubzansky, Madeline Buckley, Sam Charles and Olivia Olander
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Latasha Johnson laid her mother to rest on Thursday at the South Chicago Chapel, just hours before the funeral home rose to a level of infamy that Johnson could not have anticipated when she set out to give her mother a final goodbye.

As the funeral service began to wind down, Johnson said, about 30 police cars surrounded the South Deering building, where they would soon make a gruesome discovery.

After receiving a complaint, police officers and a state regulator found more than 50 decomposing bodies at the funeral home at 2939 E. 95th St. The complaint had reported that remains were not being properly stored at or below

40 degrees Fahrenheit, according to police reports.

In the wake of the discovery, authorities began an investigation into the funeral home as well as a large-scale effort to identify and examine all the remains. Community members and politicians condemned the treatment of people’s remains and called for criminal charges and more regulation of the funeral industry, while family members of the deceased grappled with the horror of what happened to their loved ones.

The Chicago Police Department’s Calumet Area Detectives are conducting a criminal investigation, a spokesman said.

“I want to see some justice,”

Johnson said. “I want to see them not get any more licenses. I want them to go to jail.”

Records identified the owners and operators of the funeral home as Clark and Johanna Morgan, who have a history of allegations of misconduct in the course of their work in the local funeral industry. Attorneys for the Morgans did not respond to requests for comment. No one answered the door at the Morgans’ southwest suburban home Friday morning.

Mayor Brandon Johnson on Friday condemned the funeral home for appearing to profoundly violate the trust of families in their

See **BODIES** on Page A4



Pyrotechnics skills are part of the show at the Chicago Snowballs’ “sportstainment” experience at Wintrust Field in Schaumburg on Sunday. **KARIE ANGELL LUC/FOR THE DAILY HERALD**

No second bananas on this team

How the Chicago Snowballs combine baseball with a ‘traveling circus’

By Chris Placek
DAILY HERALD

Choreographed dance moves, like a boy band from the ‘90s. An acrobatic “Lion King”-inspired Simba lift.

A juggling pirate on a unicycle.

Pyrotechnics and a snowball fight (real fire, but cotton balls,

because after all, it’s summer).

This, plus more, was the scene on a recent Sunday afternoon at Wintrust Field in Schaumburg, where, yes, a baseball game happened to break out in the middle of it all, too.

The Chicago Snowballs — the local answer to the antics of the Savannah Bananas — are on an inaugural season tour to

bring family-friendly “sportstainment” to baseball stadiums throughout the Midwest.

“We’re a traveling circus,” said Cherie Travis, the team founder and CEO.

Indeed, that’s the idea behind the two-hour-long spectacle that mixes live baseball with

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Court: Ballroom work has to cease

Trump blasts ruling requiring Congress’ approval for project

By Darlene Superville and Michael Kunzelman
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — A divided federal appeals court ruled Friday that President Donald Trump’s administration must stop construction of the \$400 million White House ballroom because Congress has not approved the project, a decision he blasted as “unjust” while vowing to appeal it to the nation’s highest court.

Trump doesn’t have the unilateral authority to build a 90,000-square-foot ballroom where the White House’s East Wing stood before he ordered its demolition last fall, according to the decision by a three-judge panel from the U.S. Court of Appeals for the District of Columbia Circuit.

The Republican president said in a post on social media that he would be appealing what he called an “unjust decision” to the U.S. Supreme Court.

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